Deferral Recovery Plan: Get Back In Fast

Plasma Pay Calculator — plasmapaycalculator.com

Getting deferred means lost income. Here's how to fix the most common deferrals and get back to donating ASAP.

Low Hematocrit / Low Iron (Most Common)

Threshold: Hematocrit must be 38%+ (women) or 39%+ (men)

Recovery Plan (3-7 days):

- Take iron supplement (65mg elemental iron) with vitamin C daily
- Eat iron-rich foods: red meat, spinach, fortified cereal, lentils
- Avoid calcium, coffee, and tea within 2 hours of iron supplement
- Cook in cast iron cookware (leaches iron into food)
- Hydrate well — dehydration concentrates blood but can worsen hematocrit reading

Low Protein (Total Protein < 6.0 g/dL)

Recovery Plan (3-5 days):

- Increase protein to 80-100g/day (chicken, eggs, fish, whey protein)
- Eat protein with every meal and snack
- Avoid alcohol (depletes protein levels)
- Stay hydrated but don't over-hydrate (dilutes protein levels)

High Blood Pressure (>180/100)

Recovery Plan:

- Deep breathing exercises for 10 minutes before your appointment
- Arrive early and sit calmly for 15 minutes
- Reduce sodium intake for 48 hours before
- Avoid caffeine the morning of your appointment

- If persistent, see your doctor — may indicate a health issue

High Pulse (>100 bpm)

Recovery Plan:

- Skip caffeine on donation day
- Practice slow breathing (4 seconds in, 6 seconds out)
- Arrive 15 minutes early and sit quietly
- Avoid rushing to the center
- Stay calm during the screening — white coat syndrome is real

Medication-Related Deferral

- **Antibiotics:** Wait until course is complete + 24-72 hours
- **Blood thinners:** Permanent deferral at most centers
- **Accutane:** 30-day deferral after last dose
- **Vaccines:** Varies — COVID (no deferral), flu (no deferral), live vaccines (2-8 weeks)
- **Always:** Bring a list of all medications to your screening

Quick Reference: Deferral Recovery Cheat Sheet

Deferral Type	Recovery Time	#1 Fix
Low Iron/Hematocrit	3-7 days	Iron supplement + vitamin C
Low Protein	3-5 days	80g+ protein daily
High BP	Same day possible	Arrive early, breathe deeply
High Pulse	Same day possible	Skip caffeine, sit calmly
Antibiotics	1-3 days post-course	Complete full course first
Tattoo/Piercing	3-12 months	Wait it out (state dependent)
Travel	Varies	Check center's travel policy

> **Pro Tip:** Every deferral costs you $50-75 in lost income. Consistent iron supplementation and hydration prevent the vast majority of deferrals.